

Lab: Strategic Thinking Workshop

Objective

Apply Active Inference cognition to the strategic challenges of your invention. You will design a business model as a generative model, analyze your competitive position through model comparison, build scenario plans for uncertain futures, and conduct a metacognitive audit of your strategic blind spots.

Materials and Prerequisites

- Your invention concept, ecosystem map, and stakeholder profiles from Modules 01-03
- Blank Business Model Canvas template (or draw your own 9-block grid)
- Familiarity with scenario planning concepts

Part 1: Business Model as Generative Model (15 minutes)

Step 1: Describe your invention's core value proposition in one sentence.

Write your response here

Step 2: Fill in the Business Model Canvas with hypotheses. For each element, state your prediction AND your confidence level (1-10).

Canvas Element	Your Hypothesis	Confidence (1-10)	What would prove this wrong?
Customer Segments			
Value Proposition			
Channels			
Customer Relationships			
Revenue Streams			
Key Resources			
Key Activities			
Key Partnerships			
Cost Structure			

Step 3: Identify the three canvas elements where your confidence is lowest. These are your highest-priority strategic uncertainties.

Write your response here

Step 4: For each low-confidence element, what evidence would increase your confidence? How could you obtain that evidence?

Low-Confidence Element	Evidence Needed	How to Obtain It	Timeline

Part 2: Competitive Position Analysis (10 minutes)

Step 1: List your three most significant competitors (or substitute solutions). For each, describe their generative model of the market — what do they believe about customer needs and how to serve them?

Competitor	Their Model of Customer Needs	Their Model of How to Win	Where Their Model Differs from Yours
1.			
2.			
3.			

Step 2: Using Porter's framework, identify your competitive strategy. Is it cost leadership, differentiation, or focus? Explain why this strategy corresponds to reducing free energy for your target customers more effectively than competitors.

Write your response here

Step 3: What would a competitor need to observe about your actions to infer your strategy? How much of your strategic model would those observations reveal? Is there an element you should keep hidden or deliberately signal?

Write your response here

Part 3: Scenario Planning (15 minutes)

Step 1: Identify two critical uncertainties that could fundamentally change your invention's trajectory. Each should have at least two plausible outcomes.

Uncertainty	Outcome A	Outcome B	Why this is uncertain
1.			
2.			

Step 2: Combine these uncertainties into a 2x2 scenario matrix. Name each scenario.

	Uncertainty 1: Outcome A	Uncertainty 1: Outcome B
Uncertainty 2: Outcome A	Scenario 1 Name: _	Scenario 2 Name: _
Uncertainty 2: Outcome B	Scenario 3 Name: _	Scenario 4 Name: _

Step 3: For each scenario, briefly describe the world and assess your invention's viability.

Scenario 1:

Write your response here

Scenario 2:

Write your response here

Scenario 3:

Write your response here

Scenario 4:

Write your response here

Step 4: Identify strategic actions that perform well across multiple scenarios (robust strategies) versus actions that only work in one scenario (contingent strategies).

Strategy	Works in Scenarios	Type (Robust/Contingent)

Step 5: What leading indicators would tell you which scenario is unfolding? How early could you detect the relevant signals?

Write your response here

Part 4: Technology Trajectory Assessment (10 minutes)

Step 1: Identify the core technology underlying your invention. Where is it on its S-curve?

Assessment	Your Analysis
Technology name	
Current performance level	
Theoretical performance limit	
Current S-curve position (early/middle/late)	
Key bottleneck to further improvement	
Estimated timeline to practical limits	

Write your response here

Step 2: Is there a successor technology that could eventually displace yours? If so, where is that successor on its own S-curve?

Write your response here

Step 3: How does your technology trajectory assessment affect your strategic timing? Should you accelerate, maintain pace, or prepare for transition?

Write your response here

Part 5: Metacognitive Audit (10 minutes)

Step 1: List three assumptions underlying your strategic model that you have NOT tested. Be honest about what you are taking for granted.

1.

Write your response here

1.

Write your response here

1.

Write your response here

Step 2: For each untested assumption, assess the consequences if it is wrong.

Assumption	If Wrong, What Changes	Severity (Low/Medium/High)	Should I Test It Now?
1.			
2.			
3.			

Step 3: Andy Grove's question: "If we were replaced and a new team came in, what would they do differently?" Answer this honestly for your invention.

Write your response here

Step 4: What is the one thing you believe about your market that most people disagree with? (Peter Thiel's question). How would you test whether you or the consensus is correct?

Write your response here

Discussion and Debrief

1. How did quantifying your confidence in each business model element change your understanding of your strategic position?
2. Did the competitive analysis reveal any positions where your model diverges from competitors in potentially advantageous ways?
3. Which scenario felt most uncomfortable? Why? What does that discomfort reveal about your priors?

4. How did the metacognitive audit change your strategic priorities? Were there assumptions you had not realized you were making?
5. If you could obtain perfect information about one strategic uncertainty, which would you choose and why?